Public Benchmark Rescoring: does blinding change AI evaluation scores on a public benchmark?

Empirical work · Methods paper · Paper XII

Recursive Dynamics · The ARC Theory · The measurement of alignment

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Abstract

I believe advanced AI is an existential risk unless values and correction are built into how it reasons; only proof will move the world. Does blinding change AI evaluation scores on a public benchmark? Paper IV.d reported that, on the programme's own instrument, alignment scores that rose with reasoning depth for two model families under an unblinded protocol did not keep that direction under a later, blinded one; since the protocols differed in several components at once, it does not show that blinding caused the change, and a code review later found defects in the blinded run. The standing objection is external validity: the change might be a property of ARC-Align rather than of AI evaluation generally. This protocol fixes, in advance, the one test whose items the programme cannot be accused of choosing to its own advantage: the same blinding manipulation run on an established public benchmark the programme did not build, curate or control, by default MT-Bench. Blinded scoring removes the producing model's identity, provider and family markers, self-referential meta-commentary and length cues. The questions preregistered by timestamp are whether blinding changes the score (H1, the per-response difference Δ_S, direction deliberately left unregistered), whether rankings displace (H2, Kendall τ), which cue carries the effect (H3, a fractional factorial), and cross-family evaluator agreement (H4, a minimum three-model panel where fewer than three valid scores is missing, never zero). The prediction preregistered by timestamp is a non-zero Δ_S of smaller magnitude than the change Paper IV.d observed (a comparison with no common scale), with modest rank displacement, and the stated most likely outcome is a positive H1 beside a null H2. This is a protocol at the draft-registration stage, not yet registered on OSF: no data has been collected, and nothing here reports a finding.

Version 1.15 sets the paper on the presentation standard, states Paper IV.d's comparison as that paper does and updates the status of the laws and studies; Appendix A lists every version and correction.

Paper XII of the ARC Theory (the Theory of Artificial Recursive Creation), within Recursive Dynamics, in its measurement of alignment: the protocol, drafted and preregistered by timestamp, for whether Paper IV.d's blinding finding holds on a public benchmark the programme did not build. A protocol of measurement, it tests none of Laws I to V, each a law under test (Section 5 gives their status). Working paper, version 1.15, 9 November 2026; first published 14 August 2026; Appendix A lists every version and correction. DOI 10.17605/OSF.IO/3TZP7. About the author, founder of Recursive Dynamics, without an institution or a doctorate: michaeldariuseastwood.com/questions/who-is-michael-darius-eastwood; his book, *Infinite Architects* (first edition, 2 January 2026): osf.io/dqm3e. Licence: CC BY 4.0.

Contents

1 Introduction **3**
1.1 Why this is the keystone . . . 3
1.2 Our contributions and the plan of the paper . . . 4

2 The questions, fixed in advance **4**

3 The design **6**

4 The benchmark **7**

5 What this paper does and does not show **7**

6 What a result would and would not mean **8**

7 Related work **8**

8 Limitations **9**

9 Conclusion **10**

References **11**

A Version history and corrections **13**
A.1 Version 1.15 . . . 13
A.2 Earlier versions, as printed . . . 13
A.3 Dated notes, as printed . . . 15
A.4 Version 1.14 wording of passages re-set, moved or cut . . . 15
A.5 Layout . . . 17

B Priority record **18**

C Notation and glossary **19**

D How to cite this paper **20**

1 Introduction

Whether an AI system is aligned can be known only by measuring it. The author's research programme, to which this paper belongs, measures alignment with scores that other AI models give as judges, on its own benchmark, ARC-Align (Eastwood 2026b). The public benchmark MT-Bench is scored by a model judge too (Zheng et al. 2023). If a judge's score moves with what it can tell about who wrote an answer, such scores say less than they seem to. This paper asks one question of that kind: does blinding change AI evaluation scores on a public benchmark? It fixes, before any data, the test that will answer the question on a benchmark the programme did not build, and what a result would and would not mean.

Reading key. Claims come in three sizes: results, laws, frames. This is a results-class instrument paper at protocol stage: its study is written, dated and prepared as a draft registration, preregistered by timestamp and awaiting human submission, and no data has been collected. Where this paper calls a question, a prediction, a design choice or a restraint of this study registered, the word means fixed in the text of that draft registration, not registered on OSF. Nothing here reports a finding; everything here is what will count as one, fixed in advance.

1.1 Why this is the keystone

This is the keystone, because it is the one test the programme cannot be accused of designing to its own advantage. Paper IV.d reported that, on the programme's own instrument, the alignment scores that rose with reasoning depth for two model families under an unblinded protocol did not keep that direction under a later protocol with a bundle of blinding steps. Because the two protocols differed in several components at once, that paper does not show that blinding caused the change, or which direction is correct, and an internal code review of October 2026 found defects in the later run that bind every reading of it (Eastwood 2026c). The reading note of 9 November 2026 in Section 2 says how this section's words from the draft registration are read. The standing objection to that result is external validity: the effect might be a property of ARC-Align rather than of AI evaluation generally, and no amount of internal replication answers that.

The answer is to run the same manipulation on **an established public benchmark the programme did not build, did not curate and does not control.** If the blinding effect reproduces there, it is a property of AI evaluation. If it does not, it is a property of the programme's instrument, and the blinding standard should be scoped to it.

The design is deliberately unfavourable to the hypothesis, and that is the point. Using someone else's benchmark forfeits every advantage of a home instrument: the items are not chosen, the scoring rubric is not the programme's, the difficulty distribution is fixed, and any ceiling or floor in the benchmark works against detecting an effect. A result obtained under those conditions is worth more than several obtained at home.

What blinding means here is registered precisely, because the word is doing heavy lifting. Blinded scoring removes from the evaluator's view: the identity of the model that produced the response, any provider or model-family marker, self-referential meta-commentary in which a response names its own origin, and response-length cues where the rubric permits length normalisation. Unblinded scoring leaves them.

A positive result would establish that the blinding manipulation changes measured scores on an external benchmark under the registered conditions. It would not establish the size of the effect elsewhere, would not establish that any specific published leaderboard is wrong, and would not license restating other researchers' results. **That last restraint is registered because the temptation to over-read this finding is the main risk to the programme's credibility.**

Scope note, 20 September 2026: what an external benchmark removes is control of the items, which is narrower than immunity from design choice. Using a benchmark this programme did not build removes control over task construction, over the scoring rubric and over the difficulty distribution, and that is the genuine property this section relies on. It does not remove the choices this study still makes: which models and which responses enter the subset, how each cue is transformed, which evaluators sit on the panel, how the analysis is specified, and how missing scores are treated. Those choices are disciplined by being fixed in the registration text before it is submitted and carried unchanged into the run, not by being absent, and section 5 records which of them are still open. The sentence that this is the one test the programme cannot be accused of designing to its own advantage is therefore read, wherever it appears in this paper, as naming the items the programme did not choose, and not as a claim that no design choice remains; section 6's narrower statement of what a result would and would not mean governs. Nothing here concedes or alleges any impropriety in the design.

1.2 Our contributions and the plan of the paper

Our contributions are:

- a protocol, fixed before any data, for testing whether blinding changes AI evaluation scores on an established public benchmark the programme did not build, by default MT-Bench, rescoring each response under blinded and unblinded conditions (Sections 3 and 4);
- four questions preregistered by timestamp: a two-sided test of the score change (H1), rank displacement by Kendall τ (H2), which of four cues carries the effect, through a Resolution IV fractional factorial in eight runs (H3), and cross-family evaluator agreement, in which fewer than three valid scores is missing, never zero (H4), with a prediction and its stated most likely outcome (Section 2);
- the restraint, fixed in advance, on what a result would and would not mean (Section 6);
- dated notes that narrow how the keystone claim, the endpoints, the design, the benchmark and Paper IV.d's comparison are read, and record what remains open before submission (Sections 1 to 5).

Section 2 states the questions and the prediction, Section 3 the design and Section 4 the benchmark. Section 5 states what this paper does and does not show, with the study's record and the status of the theory's laws and of the programme's registered studies, and Section 6 what a result would and would not mean. Section 7 sets the protocol against prior work, Section 8 gives its limitations and Section 9 concludes. Appendix A gives the version history and every correction, Appendix B the priority record, Appendix C the notation and glossary and Appendix D how to cite the paper. Sections 2 to 6 keep their numbers from version 1.14, and its Section 1 is Section 1.1 here, so the section numbers inside the dated notes read as printed.

2 The questions, fixed in advance

Primary, H1, blinding changes the score. For each response, define Δ_S as blinded score minus unblinded score. H1 predicts a non-zero mean Δ_S, tested two-sided at $\alpha = 0.05$ with a 95 per cent interval. **The direction is not predicted**, because Paper IV.d's own sign-reversal finding makes a directional prediction unjustified, and registering a direction the programme has already seen reverse would be exactly the flexibility this document exists to remove.

Co-primary, H2, rank displacement. Scores aggregate to a ranking. H2 measures displacement between blinded and unblinded rankings by Kendall τ. **This is the contrast that matters practically**,

because a change in scores that leaves rankings intact has no consequence for how benchmarks are used, and the registration refuses to report a score effect as though it were a ranking effect.

Secondary, H3, which cue carries it. The four blinded cues are removed in a registered fractional factorial rather than all at once, so the contribution of each is estimable without a full factorial. Resolution and aliasing structure are stated in the attached design.

Secondary, H4, cross-family evaluator agreement. A minimum three-model cross-family evaluator panel scores every response. Fewer than three valid scores yields **a missing value, never a zero**, because a panel that fails silently toward zero manufactures the effect it is meant to measure.

Directional prediction, registered in advance. The author predicts a non-zero Δ_S of smaller magnitude than Paper IV.d observed, and **expects rank displacement to be modest**, because benchmark rankings are usually driven by large capability gaps that survive cue removal. The author states plainly that a null on H2 alongside a positive H1 is the most likely outcome, and that the correct reading of it is that blinding matters for measurement precision rather than for leaderboard order.

Reading note, 9 November 2026: what Paper IV.d observed is a change between two protocols, not a measured effect of blinding alone. The reason given above for leaving H1's direction unpredicted ("Paper IV.d's own sign-reversal finding"; "a direction the programme has already seen reverse") and the comparison in the prediction ("smaller magnitude than Paper IV.d observed") are the draft registration's own words, preregistered by timestamp, and are kept as printed. Paper IV.d states that its comparison "shows that the reported direction did not hold across protocols; it does not show that blinding caused the change, or which direction is correct", that the two columns of its Table 2 "report different statistics, so they are not on one scale; no test of the difference between them was made", and records the code review stated in Section 1.1 (Eastwood 2026c). Both passages are read in that sense: the direction is left unpredicted because the reported direction did not hold across two protocols that differed in several components. The prediction's comparison is with the change Paper IV.d observed between them, which shares no scale with Δ_S, so it is read as a qualitative expectation and not as a margin a result can be tested against. Section 1.1's "the effect" and its two conditionals ("If the blinding effect reproduces there"; "If it does not") are the draft registration's words too and are read in the same sense. A change in scores under blinding on the public benchmark would show that blinding moves scores there, within the restraint of Section 6, not that blinding caused the change Paper IV.d observed. No detectable change would show only that the manipulation did not move scores detectably there. Unchanged: H1, its two-sided test, the prediction and Section 1.1's conditionals, each as fixed in the draft registration.

Endpoint note, 20 September 2026: a score change, measurement precision and a stable leaderboard are three different endpoints, and no registered question estimates precision. Δ_S is defined at the head of this section as the per-response difference between the blinded and the unblinded score, and H1 is a test on its mean, which is a location parameter. Precision is a property of dispersion, and accuracy requires a defensible reference, so a non-zero mean Δ_S is evidence about level, and if anything about bias, and is not by itself evidence about either. Each of the three readings requires its own specified evidence, and this paper registers a score difference and a rank-displacement statistic, neither of which is a measure of precision or of accuracy. This reading governs the same words wherever they appear in this paper, including the abstract. The practical reading offered for H2 needs the same care. Kendall τ is 1 when the two rankings are identical and about 0 when they are unrelated, so a conventional test taken against $\tau = 0$ that fails to reject shows only that the two rankings cannot be shown to be related at all, which is the opposite of a stable leaderboard rather than evidence for one; reading a null on H2 as modest displacement instead requires a test against $\tau = 1$, or an equivalence bound on $1 - \tau$. The target null, the τ variant, the treatment of ties and the inference procedure are therefore fixed in the registration text before it is submitted, and no claim that order is practically unchanged is made except against a bound the author has approved. Where a score effect is found and rank displacement is left unresolved, what is established is a score effect on this benchmark and nothing beyond it. The statement above that a score

change leaving rankings intact has no consequence for how benchmarks are used is read narrowly, as a statement about ordering alone: scores are also used for thresholds, for gating and for reporting, and two values moving from 7 and 8 to 5 and 6 keep their order while changing whether either passes 6.5, which is an illustration of the logic and not a threshold registered here. Unchanged: the refusal to predict H1's sign and the reason given for it; the restraint stated at the close of section 1 and again in section 6, which governs; and the clause fixing the benchmark in the registration.

3 The design

Within-response, randomised, blinded-versus-unblinded rescoring on an external public benchmark, with a fractional factorial over the four cue types.

Every response is scored twice, once under each condition, by a cross-family evaluator panel, with call order randomised within block and condition coded opaquely. The unit of analysis is the response; models are a blocking factor.

Resolution-IV fractional factorial over four cues in eight runs, so main effects are unaliased with each other. The aliasing structure is published rather than described.

The draft registration also fixes how the cues are removed and states what removal cannot reach: "Removal is performed by a scripted launderer whose output is audited for surviving markers, and the audit fails the build on any hit", and "Residual leakage is acknowledged: writing style can identify a model family to a capable evaluator even after markers are stripped, which is precisely the effect under study and cannot be removed without removing the phenomenon."

Design note, 20 September 2026: the coded matrix, the defining relation and the alias set belong to the attached design and are not printed here. Resolution IV fixes only what the name fixes: no main effect is aliased with another main effect or with any two-factor interaction. It does not fix which two-factor interactions are aliased with which, nor the sign each run carries; that is settled by the design's own defining relation, which the attached design states and this paper does not print. No alias set should therefore be inferred from the resolution and the run count alone, and no particular generator should be read into the phrases above in sections 2 and 3. Because a main effect in such a design can still be aliased with a higher-order interaction, any per-cue contribution reported under H3 is conditional on the identification assumptions the attached design states, and is reported as such. Until the matrix and the defining relation are printed where a reader can reach them, the aliasing cannot be checked from this paper. Unchanged: the four cues, the eight runs and the Resolution IV choice, each of which is registered.

Correction note, 9 November 2026: with four cues in eight runs, Resolution IV fixes which two-factor interactions are aliased with which; only the sign is left to the attached design. With four two-level cues, an eight-run design of Resolution IV is one of the two half fractions defined by the interaction of all four cues, taken with a positive or a negative sign. No other choice of eight runs keeps every main effect clear of every other main effect and of every two-factor interaction. Each interaction of two cues is therefore aliased with the interaction of the other two, and each cue's main effect with the interaction of the other three. What the resolution and the run count leave to the attached design is the sign of the defining relation, and so which eight of the sixteen cue combinations are run. The design note above is kept as printed. Its sentences that the resolution does not fix which two-factor interactions are aliased with which, and that no alias set should be inferred from the resolution and the run count alone, are corrected by this note. Its sentence that the aliasing cannot be checked from this paper until the matrix is printed holds for the sign alone. Unchanged: the four cues, the eight runs and the Resolution IV choice.

4 The benchmark

Benchmark. MT-Bench, the established public multi-turn evaluation benchmark maintained by LMSYS (Zheng et al., "Judging LLM-as-a-Judge with MT-Bench and Chatbot Arena", 2023), 80 questions across eight categories with a published GPT-4 pairwise/single-answer rubric, publicly available model responses, and licence terms permitting rescoring. Rationale for the default: MT-Bench is the programme's identified keystone external benchmark (the one benchmark this programme cannot be accused of designing to its own advantage), its rubric is published verbatim, model responses are publicly hosted, and its licence permits rescoring. **The benchmark is named in the registration and cannot be swapped afterwards; swapping a benchmark after a disappointing result is the specific abuse this clause prevents.**

Benchmark note, 20 September 2026: a benchmark is fixed by its version and its cleared licence, not by its name alone. Naming the benchmark in the registration fixes which benchmark is used and closes the swap this section forbids. It does not by itself fix which release of the item set, the rubric, the split and the model responses is scored, and it does not establish that the terms under which those files are published permit rescoring and the publication of derived scores. The two statements above that this benchmark's licence terms permit rescoring are therefore read as the position to be evidenced at packaging rather than as clearance already held: the licence is read at its source and its terms recorded with the date they were read, and the item set, the rubric, the split and the model roster are each recorded by their content hashes, before any response is scored. If the terms read at that point do not permit the rescoring or the publication of derived scores, that is recorded and put to the author before submission, not resolved by exchanging the benchmark. Unchanged: the benchmark named in this section, and the clause forbidding its replacement after a result.

5 What this paper does and does not show

What it shows. This paper sets out, before any data, the design of one study: its questions, prediction, method and restraint, preregistered by timestamp in a draft registration, its default benchmark, and the dated notes that govern how they are read. Its contribution is that design.

What it does not show. It reports no measurement, so it shows nothing yet about whether blinding changes AI evaluation scores, on this benchmark or any other. It tests none of the theory's laws, whose status is given below.

The study's record. The draft registration's full title is "Does the Blinding Effect Survive on Someone Else's Benchmark? A Preregistered Rescoring of an Established Public Benchmark Under Blinded and Unblinded Conditions". It is drafted, dated and prepared as a draft registration awaiting human submission, and its design is preregistered by timestamp: it was lodged privately on OSF, dated 24 August 2026; its bytes are anchored in Bitcoin block 965152 of 2 September 2026, and it was first anchored in block 962066 of 12 August 2026. Each of those dates has its kind: the two anchors are Bitcoin timestamps, and the date of the private lodging is set by OSF's server. Appendix B gives the other dated records of the design, each with its kind of date. The draft registration has not been submitted, nothing has been run, and no result is claimed. Three conditions remain open on the working unit and are recorded there rather than glossed: the concrete sample size is computed at packaging from the benchmark's own published variance data; the named benchmark defaults to MT-Bench per the programme's keystone plan, subject to the author's override before submission; and the unit's own re-verification is pending. The public OSF component for this paper is osf.io/3tzp7.

The programme's registered studies. The theory registration's current version is 1.104, approved on 29 October 2026 (DOI 10.17605/OSF.IO/P8CKQ; Eastwood 2026d). The programme's first registered study, Unit 06, a classification audit that tests no law, was registered on 1 October 2026 (DOI 10.17605/OSF.IO/RV2B5; Eastwood 2026f) and ran on 6 October 2026. It is reported in full with its five deviations as administratively incomplete, with no inferential verdict (results: DOI 10.17605/OSF.IO/4BPHG; Eastwood 2026g). Unit 83, the counted test of P21 under Law V, was registered on 22 October 2026 (DOI 10.17605/OSF.IO/MN73W; Eastwood 2026i) and ran on 27 and 28 October 2026: P21 is supported under the registered test, by the programme's own run, on the access axis, family-dependent, with its mechanism axis not evaluable and one call retried under a disclosed recovery amendment (results: DOI 10.17605/OSF.IO/98HKR; Eastwood 2026j). Unit 82 was registered on 27 October 2026 (DOI 10.17605/OSF.IO/JUFG4; Eastwood 2026h) and has not yet run. The programme's other study designs, this one among them, are drafts awaiting the author's submission, most of them preregistered by timestamp; the programme lists them at https://www.michaeldariuseastwood.com/research/registered-programme/.

The theory's laws. P15, which carries Law IV, and P12 and P21, which carry Law V, are none of the study's questions, as the dated note of 5 October 2026 (Appendix A.3) first recorded.

Epistemic status. What this programme names Laws are conjectures. Laws I to III, registered on 8 September 2026, are laws under test. Every law is a law under test until a registered test returns its verdict. Laws IV and V were added on 24 September 2026 and registered as laws on 15 October 2026 in version 1.103 of the theory registration, and their mathematics is in development, at version 1.2 of 29 October 2026 (DOI 10.17605/OSF.IO/4B3VT; Eastwood 2026a). Law IV is not yet tested. Law V is a law under test: on Unit 83's result, its placement limb is printed, as the registration's verdict rule requires, as "supported on the performance axis only, which is not support for the information-asymmetry mechanism" (Eastwood 2026d), and its build-order limb, read on P12, is undecided, since P12 is untested. Every quantity in this paper is operationally defined, and established-law standing is claimed nowhere. The registered programme exists to earn that standing, or lose it, by measurement, replication and survived refutation.

6 What a result would and would not mean

A positive result would establish that the blinding manipulation changes measured scores on an external benchmark under the registered conditions. It would not establish the size of the effect elsewhere, would not establish that any specific published leaderboard is wrong, and would not license restating other researchers' results. **That last restraint is registered because the temptation to over-read this finding is the main risk to the programme's credibility.**

7 Related work

The programme's record. The blinding finding this study externalises is that of Paper IV.d, the programme's measurement-discipline paper, stated in its own words in the reading note of Section 2 (Eastwood 2026c); the benchmark on which it was observed, ARC-Align, is specified in Paper IV.c (Eastwood 2026b). The theory this instrument serves is set out in the statement paper (Eastwood 2026e).

Biases of model judges. That model judges respond to the kinds of cue this protocol removes is established in settings other than this one. Zheng et al. (2023), who introduced MT-Bench, examine the position, verbosity and self-enhancement biases of model judges and report that GPT-4 as a judge

agrees with human preferences over 80 per cent of the time; they write that, with limited data and small differences, their study could not determine whether the models exhibit a self-enhancement bias. Koo et al. (2024) find, across sixteen models and six biases, that models are biased evaluators of text quality and that "all models are dramatically influenced by real model names". Saraf et al. (2025) had blog posts written by three vendors' models judged by all three under four labelling conditions, report that false attribution "frequently reversed preference rankings", and call for blind evaluation protocols. Panickssery et al. (2024) report that models such as GPT-4 and Llama 2 distinguish their own outputs from those of other models and of humans with non-trivial accuracy, and a linear correlation, under fine-tuning, between that self-recognition and the strength of self-preference. Dubois et al. (2024) report that a preference for longer outputs remains in existing automated evaluation metrics, and control for it with a regression that predicts the judge's preference as if the two outputs had the same length. Chae et al. (2026) find that, on items that carry no stylistic fingerprint, self-preference disappears under blind evaluation, with a small effect remaining in the opposite direction once selection quality and judge severity are controlled, while self- and other-labels alone shift scores in both directions.

Judge panels and changes of judge. Two studies of 2026 bear on how H4 and the design are read. Kohli (2026) reports that, for nine frontier models from seven families judging classification and pairwise-preference items against labelled answers, correlated errors left the panel with about two independent votes' worth of information, so agreement among judges is not a count of independent votes. Yang et al. (2026) report that a judge's score can move when the candidate responses stay fixed and only the evaluator changes, and that stronger judges reduce but do not remove position and verbosity bias. The design here scores each response under both conditions (Section 3), and the panel is among the choices that, by the scope note of 20 September 2026, are fixed in the registration text before it is submitted (Section 1.1); H4's words are unchanged.

What this protocol adds. Against the works above, read at their sources on 9 November 2026, this paper adds a protocol fixed in advance: a within-response comparison of blinded and unblinded scoring on an established public benchmark the programme did not build, with the contribution of each removed cue estimated through a fractional factorial, and the restraint on what a result would mean fixed before any data. It does not add the discovery that judges are biased or that labels and other cues move them, and it reports no result.

8 Limitations

Each limitation below is stated in full where the paper first needs it, and only named here.

- **No data.** This is a protocol: the draft registration has not been submitted, nothing has been run and no result is claimed (Section 5).
- **One benchmark.** A positive result would show that the blinding manipulation changes measured scores on that benchmark under the registered conditions, and nothing beyond it (Section 6).
- **What blinding cannot remove.** Writing style can still identify a model family to a capable judge after the markers are stripped, as the draft registration acknowledges, so blinded scoring removes the named cues and not every route to a response's origin (Section 3).
- **Choices that remain the study's own.** An outside benchmark removes control of the items, not every design choice: the subset, the cue transformations, the panel, the analysis and the treatment of missing scores are fixed in the registration text, and the sample size, the choice of benchmark and the unit's re-verification remain open before submission (Sections 1.1 and 5).

- **The design's matrix is not printed here.** Which two-factor interactions are aliased with which follows from the resolution and the run count, but the sign of the defining relation, and so which eight of the sixteen cue combinations are run, cannot be checked from this paper until the coded matrix is printed where a reader can reach it (Section 3).
- **What the endpoints measure.** No registered question estimates precision, and a null on H2 against $\tau = 0$ is not evidence of a stable leaderboard (Section 2).
- **The benchmark's licence and release.** Whether its licence permits rescoring and the publication of derived scores, and which release of its files is scored, are evidenced at packaging (Section 4).
- **Judges are models.** The evaluator panel's judges may share errors, so their agreement under H4 is not a count of independent votes (Section 7).
- **The prediction's comparison.** Paper IV.d observed a change between two protocols that differed in several components, with its later run under a code-review caveat; that is not a measured effect of blinding alone, and the change shares no scale with Δ_S (Sections 1.1 and 2).

9 Conclusion

Whether blinding changes AI evaluation scores is a question about the instruments on which claims of alignment rest. This paper fixes, before any data, how that question will be put to a public benchmark the programme did not build: four questions and a prediction preregistered by timestamp, a within-response design, a benchmark that cannot be swapped once named in the draft registration, and a restraint on what any result would mean. It reports no result yet; when the study has been registered on OSF and run, its result will be read within that restraint.

Standing covenant. Prove this paper wrong, and I will publish the refutation myself. Falsification conditions are stated in this paper; the standing challenge: github.com/MichaelDariusEastwood/arc-scaling-challenge.

Acknowledgements

Michael Darius Eastwood conceived and directs this research programme and is the author of this work. Across the programme, he has used more than six AI systems in parallel, under his own instructions, to stress-test his arguments, identify possible errors, and assist in preparing draft text from his own outlines. He determines what is adopted, revised or rejected and takes responsibility for the published content. These systems are tools, not authors.

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Michael Darius Eastwood. The ARC Theory: Growth, correction and alignment in recursive systems. OSF, 2026e. The statement paper of the ARC Theory. Cited edition: version 7.8, 9 November 2026. First published 14 August 2026. doi:10.17605/OSF.IO/GW5MX.

Michael Darius Eastwood. What Class of Corrector Is Deployed AI Alignment Actually Using? A Preregistered Classification Audit Against a Four-Cell Taxonomy. OSF Registries, 2026f. Unit 06, the corrector-class audit; registered 1 October 2026, public from 4 October 2026. doi:10.17605/OSF.IO/RV2B5.

Michael Darius Eastwood. Unit 06 (corrector-class audit): results of the registered run, rv2b5. OSF, 2026g. Deposited 11 October 2026; the run of 6 October 2026, reported as administratively incomplete, with no inferential verdict. doi:10.17605/OSF.IO/4BPHG.

Michael Darius Eastwood. Testing the premise beneath Law III's value two (P17): do correctors drawn from one engine miss the same planted departures more often than independence allows? A counted test. OSF Registries, 2026h. Unit 82, the corrector-panel independence test; registered and public 27 October 2026. doi:10.17605/OSF.IO/JUFG4.

Michael Darius Eastwood. Testing Law V (the placement limb, P21): does correction inside each revision round pull away, as depth rises, from a monitor that sees only the finished register? A counted test.

OSF Registries, 2026i. Unit 83, the counted test of P21; submitted 22 October 2026, public from 25 October 2026. doi:10.17605/OSF.IO/MN73W.

Michael Darius Eastwood. Unit 83 (counted test of P21): results of the registered run, mn73w. OSF, 2026j. Results first deposited 29 October 2026, for the registered run of 27 and 28 October 2026. doi:10.17605/OSF.IO/98HKR.

Guneet Kohli. Nine judges, two effective votes: correlated errors undermine LLM evaluation panels, 2026. URL https://arxiv.org/abs/2605.29800. arXiv:2605.29800, version 1 of 28 May 2026.

Ryan Koo, Minhwa Lee, Vipul Raheja, Jong Inn Park, Zae Myung Kim, and Dongyeop Kang. Benchmarking cognitive biases in large language models as evaluators. In *Findings of the Association for Computational Linguistics: ACL 2024*. Association for Computational Linguistics, 2024. doi:10.18653/v1/2024.findings-acl.29. Pages 517 to 545. First posted as arXiv:2309.17012, 29 September 2023.

Arjun Panickssery, Samuel R. Bowman, and Shi Feng. LLM evaluators recognize and favor their own generations, 2024. URL https://arxiv.org/abs/2404.13076. arXiv:2404.13076, 15 April 2024.

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Zongyou Yang, Yinghan Hou, and Xiaokun Yang. When the judge changes, so does the measurement: auditing LLM-as-judge reliability, 2026. URL https://arxiv.org/abs/2607.08535. arXiv:2607.08535, version 1 of 9 July 2026.

Lianmin Zheng, Wei-Lin Chiang, Ying Sheng, Siyuan Zhuang, Zhanghao Wu, Yonghao Zhuang, Zi Lin, Zhuohan Li, Dacheng Li, Eric P. Xing, Hao Zhang, Joseph E. Gonzalez, and Ion Stoica. Judging LLM-as-a-judge with MT-Bench and Chatbot Arena. In *Advances in Neural Information Processing Systems 36 (NeurIPS 2023), Datasets and Benchmarks Track*, 2023. doi:10.52202/075280-2020. URL https://arxiv.org/abs/2306.05685. Pages 46595 to 46623. Also arXiv:2306.05685, first posted 9 June 2023.

A Version history and corrections

A.1 Version 1.15

Version 1.15, 9 November 2026. The paper is set on the programme's presentation standard, as its next version in the same DOI lineage. No registered question, hypothesis, prediction, benchmark, restraint or date of this study changes, no data has been collected, and the first-published date of 14 August 2026 is unchanged. The changes, one by one:

- The title is *Public Benchmark Rescoring: does blinding change AI evaluation scores on a public benchmark?*; until this version it read "Paper XII · The ARC Theory · Public Benchmark Rescoring: an External-Validity Protocol for the Blinding Finding", with the question line "Does the blinding effect survive on someone else's benchmark?" beneath it, which stays where the draft registration's full title is quoted (Section 5).
- The abstract opens with the author's reason for the work and the paper's question, and, with Section 1.1, states Paper IV.d's comparison as that paper states it: the reported direction did not hold across protocols, that paper does not show that blinding caused the change, and an internal code review of October 2026 found defects in the later run. The abstract no longer calls the comparison a sign reversal, reads the keystone sentence as its scope note of 20 September 2026 does, states the prediction's comparison as one of magnitude, with no common scale, and leaves the prediction's reading about precision to Section 2.
- The questions, the prediction, the design, the benchmark clause and the restraint are kept word for word, as preregistered by timestamp; a dated reading note in Section 2 says how H1's reason, the prediction's comparison, which shares no scale with Δ_S, and the conditionals of Section 1.1 are read against Paper IV.d's own words. Section 3 quotes the draft registration's statement of how the cues are removed and what removal cannot reach, and a correction note there states that, with four cues in eight runs, Resolution IV fixes which two-factor interactions are aliased with which, up to the sign of the defining relation; the design note of 20 September 2026 is kept as printed.
- Section 5, renamed, states what the paper does and does not show, the study's record, the programme's registered studies (the theory registration at version 1.104; Units 06, 83 and 82, with Unit 83's result on P21) and the theory's laws: Laws IV and V were registered as laws on 15 October 2026 in version 1.103, each law is a law under test, and their mathematics is cited at version 1.2. The other dated records of the design move to Appendix B.
- Related work (Section 7), limitations (Section 8) and a conclusion (Section 9) are added; the paragraph on related papers, now the first of Section 7, no longer says that the direction changed once scoring was blinded in Paper IV.d.
- Two repeats leave the main text, each kept in Appendix A.4: the benchmark's citation sentence, which the references carry, and the last paragraph of Section 6, which repeated the one before it.
- The paper is licensed under CC BY 4.0; the author block and the copyright line take the programme's standard forms; the site's how-to-cite block gives way to Appendix D, whose citation names no venue and no series, the form the programme's other citations take.
- Every mention of one of the author's papers links its OSF DOI, and every reference links its official source.

A.2 Earlier versions, as printed

Each entry is printed as it was written, with its version and date set as its heading; the section numbers in it are those of its version, which Sections 1 to 6 here keep.

Version 1.14, 5 October 2026: the title now follows the programme's uniform order (paper, its law or framework, its own title), *Paper XII · The ARC Theory · Public Benchmark Rescoring: an External-Validity Protocol for the Blinding Finding*; until this version it read *Paper XII: Public Benchmark Rescoring*. The plate beneath the author line now gives the paper's place in the programme in the words of the programme's map. A dated note places the paper against Laws IV and V. No registered law, prediction, kill condition or dependency changes; no result is added; no date of any claim moves.

Version 1.13, 3 October 2026: the paper is brought into line with the theory as it now stands and with the record of the work it cites. The abstract and section 1 now report Paper IV.d's comparison as that paper reports it, without pinning the change on blinding alone. The abstract now says preregistered by timestamp where it called this study's questions, its factorial and its prediction registered, and gives the stage as the draft-registration stage, not yet registered on OSF. The reading key, section 5, the footer line and the page's summary descriptions now give this study as preregistered by timestamp; the reading key says how the word registered is read in this paper, and section 5 gives the study's timestamp record, the other dated records of its design, each with its kind of date, and the state of the programme's trials as read on 3 October 2026. The paragraph on related papers now calls what Paper IV.d reports a finding, not a law, and no longer says that its blinding reversal produced the programme's retraction, which is Paper II's; it gives the reversal as Paper IV.d reports it, for two model families. The epistemic status line gives Laws I to III and Laws IV and V, which were added to the theory on 24 September 2026, their separate status, and names the mathematics of Laws IV and V at version 1.0. A dated note records what each corrected passage printed before. Citations are linked: mentions of the author's papers go to their DOIs, and the benchmark paper, the two sources the authorship notice names and the author's book to their official addresses. No registered law, prediction, kill condition or dependency changes; no result is added; no date of any claim moves.

Version 1.12, 20 September 2026: four dated notes have been added beside the passages they govern, and each is substantive. A scope note in section 1 records that using an external benchmark removes control of the items rather than every design choice, and that section 6's narrower statement governs wherever the stronger sentence appears. An endpoint note in section 2 records that a score change, measurement precision and a stable leaderboard are three different endpoints, that a null on H2 taken against tau = 0 is a failure to show the rankings related rather than evidence of a stable leaderboard, and that the target null, the tau variant, the treatment of ties and the inference procedure are fixed in the registration text before it is submitted. A design note in section 3 records that the coded matrix, the defining relation and the alias set belong to the attached design and are not printed here. A benchmark note in section 4 records that the licence position and the version of the scored files are evidenced at packaging rather than inferred from a page. Editorially, the machine citation block's version and modified date and the Scholar and Dublin Core metadata have been brought into step with the dateline, and the entry below has been moved to the separator this footer uses for superseded entries. No registered question, no hypothesis, no date, no result and no status has changed, no data has been collected, and the first-published date of 14 August 2026 is unchanged.

Version 1.11, 13 September 2026: The provenance note at the end has been corrected for accuracy. No claim, date, result or status has changed.

Version 1.10, 2 September 2026: the machine citation block now carries this paper's own DOI (10.17605/OSF.IO/3TZP7) in place of the programme umbrella, and its journal field was brought into line with the Scholar metadata. In the dateline the version now precedes the DOI.

Version 1.9, 27 August 2026: metadata added to aid discovery.

A.3 Dated notes, as printed

These two dated notes are printed as they were written; the current statements they concern are in the abstract and Sections 1, 5 and 7.

Correction note, 3 October 2026: the passages named here are corrected in place, and this note records what each printed before. The abstract and section 1 each said that Paper IV.d "established that blinding changes measured alignment outcomes on the programme's own instrument". Paper IV.d's own abstract has said since 2 September 2026 that its unblinded and blinded protocols differ in more than one component, and that its comparison does not pin the change on blinding alone. Both passages now report the change as that paper does. The abstract also called this study's questions, its factorial and its prediction registered, and said "This is a protocol at registration stage". The study is a draft, so the abstract now says preregistered by timestamp in each of those places, and gives the stage as the draft-registration stage, not yet registered on OSF. Section 5 said that "nothing has been submitted". One unit of the programme has since been submitted for registration, and the section now gives this study's timestamp record and the state of the programme's trials as read on 3 October 2026. It also gives the other dated records of the design that the programme's record of this paper holds, each with its kind of date. The reading key and the footer line gave this study only as awaiting submission; each now also says that it is preregistered by timestamp, and the reading key says how the word registered is read in this paper. The paragraph on related papers opened "The blinding law this study externalises" and said that Paper IV.d's blinding reversal produced the programme's one public retraction. What Paper IV.d reports is not one of the theory's five laws, and the paragraph now calls it a finding. The retraction is Paper II's: in its blinded cross-architecture replication, an initial single-model super-linear estimate did not replicate and is retracted. The paragraph now says only what Paper IV.d itself reports, the blinding reversal for two model families. The epistemic status line read "What this programme names Laws are conjectures under registered adversarial test"; it now gives Laws I to III and Laws IV and V their separate status. Unchanged: every registered question, hypothesis and prediction of this study, the benchmark it names and the clause forbidding its replacement, and the restraint stated in sections 1 and 6, which governs.

This paper and Laws IV and V, 5 October 2026. Law IV, the ARC Persistence Law, is carried by proposition P15, and Law V, the ARC Embedding Law, by propositions P12 and P21. The study this protocol fixes in advance tests none of the three, and naming the two laws changes nothing printed here.

A.4 Version 1.14 wording of passages re-set, moved or cut

The version 1.14 words of every passage this version re-sets or leaves out are printed here, except the copyright notice, which takes the programme's standard form in the back matter, and the website's own lines (its links beneath the author's name and its how-to-cite block), which give way to the first-page footnote and Appendix D. A passage moved without change keeps its words where it now stands, as Table 1 shows.

The title. Paper XII · The ARC Theory · Public Benchmark Rescoring: an External-Validity Protocol for the Blinding Finding

The line beneath the author's name. Independent AI alignment researcher, London · Author, *Infinite Architects* (2026)

The paper-type line, beneath the plate. The ARC Theory (the Theory of Artificial Recursive Creation) · Paper XII · Protocol paper · First published 14 August 2026, revised 5 October 2026 · Working Paper v1.14 · DOI 10.17605/OSF.IO/3TZP7

The question line, beneath the paper-type line. *Does the blinding effect survive on someone else's benchmark?*

The abstract. Paper IV.d reported that, on the programme's own instrument, the measured direction of alignment scaling changed for two model families between an unblinded and a blinded protocol. Because the two protocols differ in more than one component, that paper does not pin the change on blinding alone. The standing objection is external validity: the effect might be a property of ARC-Align rather than of AI evaluation generally. This protocol paper fixes, in advance, the one test the programme cannot be accused of designing to its own advantage: the same blinding manipulation run on an established public benchmark the programme did not build, curate or control. Blinded scoring removes the producing model's identity, provider and family markers, self-referential meta-commentary and length cues; unblinded scoring leaves them. The questions preregistered by timestamp are whether blinding changes the score (H1, the per-response difference Δ_S, direction deliberately unregistered after IV.d's own sign reversal), whether rankings displace (H2, Kendall τ), which cue carries the effect (H3, a fractional factorial preregistered by timestamp), and cross-family evaluator agreement (H4, a minimum three-model panel where fewer than three valid scores is missing, never zero). The prediction preregistered by timestamp is a non-zero Δ_S smaller than IV.d observed with modest rank displacement, and the stated most likely outcome is a positive H1 beside a null H2, read as blinding mattering for measurement precision rather than leaderboard order. This is a protocol at the draft-registration stage: preregistered by timestamp and not yet registered on OSF. No data has been collected, and nothing here reports a finding.

Section 1, its first paragraph. This is the keystone, because it is the one test the programme cannot be accused of designing to its own advantage. Paper IV.d reported that, on the programme's own instrument, the measured direction of alignment scaling changed for two model families between an unblinded and a blinded protocol. Because the two protocols differ in more than one component, that paper does not pin the change on blinding alone. The standing objection to that result is external validity: the effect might be a property of ARC-Align rather than of AI evaluation generally, and no amount of internal replication answers that.

Section 4, its second paragraph. The benchmark citation, verified against the arXiv record: Zheng, L., et al. (2023). Judging LLM-as-a-Judge with MT-Bench and Chatbot Arena. NeurIPS 2023 Datasets and Benchmarks; arXiv:2306.05685.

Section 5, its last three sentences. Of the programme's trials, one unit, the corrector-class audit (unit 06), was submitted for registration on OSF on 1 October 2026; when read on 3 October 2026 its approval period at OSF was still running and it was not yet public. Every other trial is a draft awaiting the author's submission, and most of them are preregistered by timestamp. The full listing of the programme's drafted trials is public at the drafted-trials page.

Section 6, its last paragraph. The restraint above is part of the design: the temptation to over-read an external-benchmark result is the main risk to the programme's credibility, and it is fenced in the registration itself.

Related papers of the theory. The blinding finding this study externalises: Paper IV.d (10.17605/OSF.IO/2S3E6), the measurement-discipline paper that reports the programme's blinding reversal, in which for two model families the direction of the alignment-depth relationship changed once scoring was blinded. The theory this instrument serves: the statement paper (10.17605/OSF.IO/GW5MX). The full catalogue is at the papers index.

The footer, its author line. Michael Darius Eastwood · ORCID 0009-0004-3222-7442 · Licence: none is stated here; the terms are in the repository's LICENCE file

The footer, its last line. The ARC Theory (the Theory of Artificial Recursive Creation) · study drafted, preregistered by timestamp and awaiting human submission · this protocol paper first published 14 August 2026

After the footer, the epistemic status line. **Epistemic status.** What this programme names Laws are conjectures. Laws I to III are under registered adversarial test. Laws IV and V were added on 24 September 2026; the predictions that carry them are registered, the laws themselves are not yet registered, and neither has been tested. Their mathematics is set out in Laws IV and V: the mathematics, version 1.0, of 3 October 2026. Every quantity in this paper is operationally defined, and established-law standing is claimed nowhere. The registered programme exists to earn that standing, or lose it, by measurement, replication and survived refutation.

A.5 Layout

Table 1. Where each part of version 1.14 stands in version 1.15.

In version 1.14	In version 1.15
Title, author lines, plate, type line and question line	Title, secondary line, author block and first-page footnote; the old forms in Appendix A.4
Reading key	Section 1, second paragraph
Abstract	Abstract, re-set; the old form in Appendix A.4
Section 1, Why this is the keystone	Section 1.1
Section 2, The questions, fixed in advance	Section 2, with a reading note of 9 November 2026
Section 3, The design	Section 3, with a correction note of 9 November 2026
Section 4, The benchmark	Section 4; the citation sentence in the references and Appendix A.4
Section 5, Status, honestly	Section 5, What this paper does and does not show; the other dated records of the design in Appendix B
Section 6, What a result would and would not mean	Section 6; its last paragraph in Appendix A.4
Related papers of the theory	Section 7, Related work
Footer lines	Title page and first-page footnote; the author line and the last line in Appendix A.4
Version history	Appendix A.2
Epistemic status	Section 5; the old form in Appendix A.4

In version 1.14	In version 1.15
Note on Laws IV and V, 5 October 2026	Appendix A.3
Correction note, 3 October 2026	Appendix A.3
Copyright and authorship notice	Back matter: the copyright line in the programme's standard form
Standing covenant	Back matter
The author's disclosure	Acknowledgements
How to cite	Appendix D, re-set

B Priority record

Each dated record of the study's design and of this paper's publication is listed with its identifier and the kind of its timestamp: a Bitcoin anchor, a date set by a server (OSF's or GitHub's), or a date written inside a record or a document. No kind is presented as stronger than it is. The paragraph after the table is printed as version 1.14 printed it in its Section 5.

Table 2. The dated records of the study's design and of this paper, each with its kind of timestamp.

Date	Record	Identifier	Kind of timestamp
6 July 2026	Initial preregistration text, with an amendment of the same date; it describes an earlier design	the programme's record of this paper	a date written in the record; no server date and no anchor
7 August 2026	The text prepared for OSF, stating the four questions of Section 2	the programme's record of this paper	a date written in the record
7 August 2026	This paper's public OSF component created	osf.io/3tzp7, DOI 10.17605/OSF.IO/3TZP7	set by OSF's server (23:10:15 UTC)
12 August 2026	The design first anchored	Bitcoin block 962066	a Bitcoin timestamp
14 August 2026	This paper first published, stating the same four questions; its files deposited on OSF	the website's publication; the OSF component's files (16:29 to 16:30 UTC)	set by GitHub's server (the publication) and by OSF's server (the deposit)
24 August 2026	The draft registration lodged privately on OSF	the private OSF lodging	set by OSF's server
2 September 2026	The draft registration's bytes anchored	Bitcoin block 965152	a Bitcoin timestamp
20 September 2026	Four dated notes narrowing how the keystone claim, the endpoints, the design and the benchmark are read (version 1.12)	this paper, version 1.12	a date written in the document
3 October 2026	Correction note (version 1.13)	this paper, version 1.13 (Appendix A.3)	a date written in the document
5 October 2026	Dated note placing the study against Laws IV and V (version 1.14)	this paper, version 1.14 (Appendix A.3)	a date written in the document
9 November 2026	Reading note and correction note (version 1.15)	this paper, version 1.15 (Sections 2 and 3)	a date written in the document

The programme's record of this paper holds these other dated records of the design. An initial preregistration text, with an amendment of the same date, is dated 6 July 2026; that date is written in the record itself, which names no server date and no anchor for it, and the text of July describes an earlier design. The text prepared for OSF, which states the four questions of section 2, is dated 7 August 2026, again by a date written in the record. This paper's public OSF component was created on 7 August 2026, a date set by OSF's server. This paper, which states the same four questions, was first published on 14 August 2026; GitHub's server sets the date of its publication, and OSF's the date on which its files were deposited there.

C Notation and glossary

Each symbol and term is listed with its meaning and where it is first defined.

Table 3. Symbols and terms used in this paper.

Symbol or term	Meaning	First defined in
Δ_S	For each response, the blinded score minus the unblinded score	Section 2 (H1)
H1, H2, H3, H4	The four questions: whether blinding changes the score; rank displacement; which cue carries the effect; cross-family evaluator agreement	Section 2
$\alpha = 0.05$	The level of H1's two-sided test, reported with a 95 per cent interval	Section 2 (H1)
Kendall τ	The rank correlation by which H2 measures displacement: 1 when the two rankings are identical and about 0 when they are unrelated	Section 2 (H2 and the endpoint note)
$1 - \tau$	The quantity on which an equivalence bound would be set before a null on H2 could be read as modest displacement	Section 2 (the endpoint note)
Resolution IV	A fractional factorial design in which no main effect is aliased with another main effect or with any two-factor interaction	Section 3 (the design note)
Cue	One of the four features blinded scoring removes: the producing model's identity, any provider or model-family marker, self-referential meta-commentary, and response-length cues where the rubric permits length normalisation	Section 1.1
Blinded, unblinded scoring	Scoring with the four cues removed from the evaluator's view, and with them left	Section 1.1
Panel	The minimum three-model cross-family evaluator panel; fewer than three valid scores is a missing value, never a zero	Section 2 (H4)
Registered (in this paper)	Fixed in the text of the draft registration, not registered on OSF	Section 1 (reading key)
Preregistered by timestamp	Fixed by dated records before submission: here a private OSF lodging and two Bitcoin anchors	Section 5; Appendix B

Symbol or term	Meaning	First defined in
MT-Bench	The default benchmark: 80 questions across eight categories, with a published rubric and publicly available model responses	Section 4

D How to cite this paper

Cite this paper as. Eastwood, M. D. (2026). *Public Benchmark Rescoring: does blinding change AI evaluation scores on a public benchmark?* https://doi.org/10.17605/OSF.IO/3TZP7. A citation of an earlier version keeps the title that version printed.

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  author = {Eastwood, Michael Darius},
  title  = {Public Benchmark Rescoring: does blinding change
            {AI} evaluation scores on a public benchmark?},
  year   = {2026},
  doi    = {10.17605/OSF.IO/3TZP7}
}
```